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Best Practices for Training Non-specialist Caregivers in Diarrhea Management in Rwanda



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Introduction

Diarrheal diseases remain a leading cause of illness and death among children under five in Rwanda, despite being largely preventable and treatable. In rural and resource-limited communities, the shortage of trained healthcare professionals means that much of the responsibility for early detection and care falls on non-specialist caregivers—such as parents, community health workers, and informal care providers. Equipping these individuals with practical, evidence-based knowledge and skills is critical for improving health outcomes. This report outlines best practices for training non-specialist caregivers in the effective management of diarrhea, with a focus on culturally appropriate strategies, low-cost interventions, and community-based education programs tailored to the Rwandan context.

Target Groups

Demographic Characteristics

Caregivers of children under 5.

Female caregivers
(relationship with child health).

Existing Community Structures

Leverage local women's groups, faith-based organizations, or village health committees that already gather caregivers.

Caregiver Role

Household caregivers.

Community-based caregivers (community health workers, birth attendants).

Community Health Workers (CHW) are government-trained volunteers providing basic health services, including diarrhea management.

Traditional Birth Attendants (TBAs) are informal maternal care providers still active in rural areas despite being phased out officially.

Training Content

Understanding of Diarrhea	Recognizing Dehydration	Solutions	Hygiene and Sanitation	Symptoms of Professional Care
Teach the causes, symptoms, and types of diarrhea, including when to worry about persistent or bloody diarrhea.	Learn to identify early signs of dehydration (dry mouth, reduced urination, etc) and know how to respond immediately.	Demonstrate the correct way to easily prepare and administer medications. Emphasize the importance of medications to reduce duration and severity.	Train caregivers in essential hygiene practices (handwashing with soap, safe food preparation, clean waste disposal, etc).	Provide a list of danger signs (high fever, repeated vomiting, lethargy, etc) that require urgent referral to health facilities.

Training Methods

- Training community health workers to train the rest of community members/target population.
- Using existing community meetings at the village level to convey our education information to the community.
- Usage of visual tools (flipcharts, posters, video tutorials in various languages) to simplify complex health concepts, maximize communication.
- Peer-to-peer education from caregivers to another + easy means of raising awareness to children.

Training Methods Examples

Common terminology with regional metaphors

- A child suffering with diarrhea is like a dry banana leaf left out in the sun: weak, brittle, and dull."
- ORS treatment can bring the leaf back to life, making it soft and strong again. It refills the body with water and makes it active again.
- If diarrhea is a wildfire, unlike ORS that puts out the fire, Zinc supplements plant new seeds to keep the fire from returning.

Communication in Kinyarwanda

1. Oral Rehydration Therapy (ORT)

"Amazi y'ubuzima (Water of Life)"
A salty-sweet drink that replaces the water and salts a child loses during diarrhea. It keeps the child strong and prevents dangerous dehydration.

2. Zinc Supplements

"Umuti w'imbaraga (Strength Medicine)"
A small tablet or syrup given for 10 days to help diarrhea stop faster and protect the child from getting it again soon.

3. Vitamin A Supplements

"Ijisho ry'umwana (The Child's Eye Protector)"
A strong vitamin that helps protect a child's eyesight and boosts their ability to fight off diarrhea and other illnesses.

4. Probiotic Supplements

"Umuti w'inda (Stomach Fixers)"
Healthy bacteria (from yogurt or powder) that help the child's stomach heal and get back to normal after diarrhea

Conclusion

Training non-specialist caregivers in diarrhea management is a practical, scalable intervention that aligns with Rwanda's community-driven health approach. By using interactive methods, delivering culturally relevant content, and engaging local systems for implementation, these programs can improve child survival rates. More importantly, they empower communities with the tools and knowledge to take control of their health. Expanding and sustaining these training initiatives is a critical step toward achieving national health goals and ensuring every Rwandan child has a healthier start to life.